Checking Up on a Deployed Application

Once we have our application deployed, we'll no doubt need to check up from time to time on how it's running. We can do this in two primary ways. The first is to monitor the various log files output by both our front-end web server and the nginx server running our application. The second is to connect to our application using `rails console`.

Looking at Log Files

To get a quick look at what's happening in our application, we can use the `tail` command to examine log files as requests are made against our application. The most interesting data will usually be in the log files from the application itself. Even if nginx is running multiple applications, the logged output for each application is placed in the `production.log` file for that application.

Assuming that our application is deployed into the location we showed earlier, here's how we look at our running log file:

```
# On your server
$ tail -f log/production.log
```

Sometimes, we need lower-level information—what's going on with the data in our application? When this is the case, it's time to break out the most useful live server debugging tool.

Using Console to Look at a Live Application

We've already created a large amount of functionality in our application's model classes. Of course, we created these to be used by our application's controllers—but we can also interact with them directly. The gateway to this world is the `rails console` script. We can launch it on our server with this:

```
# On your server
$ docker compose exec web bin/rails console
Loading production environment (Rails 7.0.4)
irb(main):001:0> p = Product.last
```